

Meditation Through Nihilism

Fifty Sits

*A practice after Temporary Truths
for Our Honest Lies*

Not a course. Not a new self.
Two pressures. No controller. One footnote.

A practice to do after *Temporary Truths for Our Honest Lies*. Not a replacement for the book. Not a course. Not a new self.

The book argues. These sits are for the body, once the words are already loaded. If a chapter is still unwritten, the sits that follow it are drawn from the locked arc. When that prose is rewritten, those sits should be revised. The accent belongs to the book.

Do not record all fifty before you have sat with the later chapters. The text is here so the shape is not lost.

What this is

Consciousness, here, means only this: what is already appearing. Sound. Weight. A thought. A twist in the gut. The thought that says "I" is one more appearance. That much is the door, and then the door is behind you.

What the book adds, and these sits refuse to drop:

- The Roar and the Quiet are both pressures. Neither is you. Neither is holy. Neither is a plan.
- Seeing that does not float you above the harm. You still have ordinary hands.
- The grab for a controller — a serpent, a they, a true self, a greatness — is the same grab.
- You subscribe to a story because it fits. You can set it down. You do not need a replacement truth in the same minute.
- Tomorrow the herd is still there. You get up into the same kitchen.

What this is not

- Not Waking Up with a darker coat. The first two sits borrow the doorway. They do not stay there.
- Not enlightenment. The Quiet is not your true self and not a

command.

- Not a manifesto. The Roar is heavy and suffocating. It is not exciting.
- Not a sorting of kinds of people. One sit, and only one, is for difference.
- Not a brief against anyone's religion. A god-shaped story is a feeling you can notice, not a target.
- Not a sit about the gun, the trigger, or dying. Care for a child is as far as that weather goes.
- Not news, and not a tour of villains.

How to sit

Once a day is enough. Ten to twelve minutes. Most of that is quiet. The words are a spine, not a talk.

Sit in a chair you already use. Eyes open or closed. No bell required. No music required. If you use a bed under the voice, keep it plain, and keep it quieter than the words. If the voice performs wisdom, it is the wrong voice. Flat, slow, slightly tired.

When a lesson starts in the mind — about how well you are doing, about what this means, about who is steering — that lesson is the narrator. Notice it. Come back to what is actually here.

You can repeat a block for a week. Repetition is the method. Three lines, until they are boring in the body: two pressures, no controller, one footnote.

Do the sits after the book, not instead of it. If you have not read the chapter a block belongs to, you may still sit, but do not treat the sit as the chapter.

Map

1–2 · Door · What is appearing. Then leave.

3–7 · Intro · The mirror. No villain yet.

- 8–13 · Chapter 1 · The graft. Ape plus story.
- 14–19 · Chapter 2 · Two pressures. Neither is you.
- 20–24 · Chapter 2 · Ordinary hands.
- 25–30 · Chapter 3 · No controller. Then set the image down.
- 31–36 · Chapter 4 · A temporary subscription.
- 37–40 · Chapter 5 · The loud now.
- 41–45 · Chapter 6 · Greatness, wearing clean clothes.
- 46–50 · Chapter 7 · The same life, lighter hands.

Each sit ends the same way. After the last line, be quiet for the rest of the time. If you need a clock, set it at the start and do not look at it again until it goes.

Sit 1 — What is appearing

Door. The only sit that borrows the other practice. Then it is finished with that.

Sit down.

Do not improve yourself for the next while. Do not understand anything.

Notice what is already happening. A sound in the room. The weight of the body on the chair. Air at the nostrils, if it is obvious. Do not hunt for a special breath.

A thought will come. Let it be there the way the sound is there. You do not have to follow it. You do not have to push it out.

If a second thought arrives to say how this should feel, that one is also just appearing.

Stay with what is actually here. Not the story of what is here.

Then be quiet.

Sit 2 — The narrator is a thought

Door. Last use of this move on its own.

Sit.

Thoughts are already talking. One of them says "I". I am doing this. I am the one who notices. I am bad at this. I already knew this.

That sentence is a thought. It appears, the way a sound appears. It is not the space it appears in.

You do not have to kill it. Killing it is just another sentence.

For a moment, let the "I" sentence be one more noise in the room.

There is seeing, hearing, thinking. The claim that someone owns them is extra. Set the claim down. You can pick it up the second you stand. It will be waiting. It always is.

Then be quiet.

Sit 3 — Cold coffee

Intro. A mirror, felt. Do not retell anyone's life.

Sit.

Something in you already knows a small shame. Not a famous one. An ordinary one. Let it come as a weight, not as a speech.

Where is it. Throat. Chest. Stomach. Face. You may not find a place. That is still a finding.

Do not explain why you did it. Do not build the case that you were young, or that everyone did it. Those sentences can wait outside.

Stay with the weight for as long as it is willing to be felt, and no longer. If it leaves, do not drag it back. Notice the room again.

You are not on trial in this chair. You are only letting a fact have a body.

Then be quiet.

Sit 4 — Disgust that feels like virtue

Intro.

Sit.

Recall, lightly, a person or a group you recently found foul. Do not import the argument. Import the feeling.

The sourness. The draw of the mouth. The small pleasure of being on the clean side of it.

That pleasure is part of the feeling. Do not pretend it is only pain.

You do not have to decide, in this sit, whether the foulness was real. You are watching how fast disgust dresses itself as sight.

Name it, once, in the body: this is heat, this is a turn of the face, this is a story arriving a second later to justify it.

Then let the picture of them go. Stay with the heat until it cools on its own.

Then be quiet.

Sit 5 — The clothes on your back

Intro. One object. No sermon about the world.

Sit.

Feel what you are wearing. Cloth on skin. Or the phone near your hand, if that is the nearer object. Pick one.

Do not research it. Do not open a fact.

Ask only this, and then drop the question: whose hands were in this before it was mine. You will not get a true answer. Notice what the mind does instead. A picture. A wince. A shrug. A boredom.

The shrug is information. The wince is information. Neither makes you good.

Feel the object again as weight and texture. That is all that is actually here.

Then be quiet.

Sit 6 — The nod you gave

Intro.

Sit.

Find one small agreement. Not a crime. A nod. A laugh you joined. A silence when someone was being shaved down to a joke.

Let the scene be short. A few seconds.

Feel the moment just before the nod. Was there a twist. Did you notice it. Did you not.

Feel the moment just after. Relief, often. Belonging. The joke completed. The room smooth again.

Do not give a speech about who you were then. Sit inside the relief until you can taste it without decorating it.

That relief is how the herd moves. It is not a monster in the corner. It is a comfort in the chest.

Then be quiet.

Sit 7 — No villain yet

Intro. Do not skip this. The later sits will try to hand you a villain. Practice not taking one.

Sit.

Bring back, lightly, the nod or the shame. No new story.

Watch the mind reach for a name. Them. The times. My father. My nature. A sickness in the group. A person who is worse.

Each name is a relief. Notice the relief. You do not have to take it.

For this sitting, leave the event without an author. Hands moved. A laugh happened. A stomach turned. That is the whole picture, and it is already enough to feel.

If a villain arrives anyway, see the sentence arrive. "There it is." Then back to weight, sound, chair.

Then be quiet.

Sit 8 — The ape underneath

Chapter 1.

Sit.

Under the commentary there is an animal that wants simple things. Warmth. Status. Food. Not to be left. To be in the middle, or at least not on the edge.

Do not make this noble. Do not make it wicked.

Where do you feel the want right now. It may be small. A restlessness. A checking. The mind reaching for the phone that is not a thought but a reach.

Let the reach be animal. It does not need a philosophy.

You are not above this body, watching a specimen. The watching is happening here too. Stay with the want until it is ordinary.

Then be quiet.

Sit 9 — The upgrade talking

Chapter 1. The graft. The story-making layer.

Sit.

Listen for the voice that explains you to yourself. It is quick. It is fluent. It has reasons.

That voice is the upgrade. It arrived late. It is good at dress. It can make hunger sound like principle, and fear sound like taste.

You do not have to shut it up. For a few minutes, hear it as a radio in another room. Clear, confident, not in charge of the furniture.

Each time it offers a reason you are sitting here — growth, guilt, curiosity, killing time — label it once: upgrade. Then feel the chair.

The ape does not talk like that. The ape shifts, wants, settles. Both are here. Do not promote the talker to captain just because it has sentences.

Then be quiet.

Sit 10 — Belonging as weather

Chapter 1. The Roar's favourite weather, before it has a moral costume.

Sit.

Remember a room where you were inside. Not famous. A kitchen, a job, a joke you were allowed to be in.

Feel the click of being included. Shoulders. Breath. The face wanting to match the other faces.

That click is not an idea. It is a change in the body, fast, before the story of why these are your people.

Let yourself feel how good it is. Do not correct it yet. If you correct it too soon you will not learn the size of it.

Now notice that the goodness does not ask what the room is doing to anyone standing just outside it. It does not have to. It is weather. Weather does not take minutes.

Stay with the click until it is familiar, not sacred.

Then be quiet.

Sit 11 — Disgust as weather

Chapter 1.

Sit.

Bring back the sour turn from earlier, or a fresh one, smaller. Someone's habit. Someone's face. Someone's belief.

Feel it as a reflex. Mouth. Nose. The lean away.

Then the upgrade arrives, almost at once, with a paragraph. This is why they are wrong. This is why you are right to lean.

Separate the two by a second, if you can. First the lean. Then the paragraph.

You are not deciding the paragraph's truth today. You are noticing that the paragraph is hired by the lean. It will work for the other lean tomorrow, in another room, with the same confidence.

Then be quiet.

Sit 12 — The pull toward a child

Chapter 1. Kin. Not a sit about death or the trigger. If this opens grief you cannot sit with, come back to the chair and the sound, and stop the picture.

Sit.

If there is a child in your life, or a child you were, let the pull be physical. The reach to feed, to check, to put a body between them and the weather. Or the memory of being the one reached for.

This pull is older than your reasons. It can make a selfish person spend themselves. It does not feel like the upgrade. It feels like a hand already moving.

Do not turn it into proof that you are good. People have done terrible things inside this same pull, for "their" young, against someone else's.

Feel only the size of it. How it can outvote laziness. How it does not outvote the herd every time.

Then let the child go. Sound. Chair. Your own weight.

Then be quiet.

Sit 13 — Ape plus story

Chapter 1. Close of the block.

Sit.

Two layers, both obvious now if you have been sitting.

The animal: want, flinch, lean-in, lean-away, the pull toward your own.

The upgrade: the talker, the reason, the name "I".

You are not invited to pick the pure one. There is no pure one. The talker is part of the animal's equipment. It does not make you a different species of being. It makes the animal able to lie, beautifully, including to itself.

Rest as both. A body that wants. A voice that explains the wanting. Neither voice is the chair you are on.

When you stand up, you will still be this. The sit does not graduate you out of it.

Then be quiet.

Sit 14 — The heavy room

Chapter 2. The Roar. Heavy. Not thrilling.

Sit.

Imagine, or remember, a room that has already decided. A meeting. A table. A comment thread you can feel in your chest. The decision is in the air before anyone makes a speech.

Feel the cost of being the one who has not decided with them. It is not a debate. It is air pressure. Thicker. Harder to breathe in your own rhythm.

Do not admire the pressure. Do not call it power. Feel it as weight on the social body: the risk of being the odd one, the wet coat, the person the room will edge out.

Let it be unpleasant. If some part of you finds it exciting to describe, notice that part. That excitement is how this weather gets sold. In the chair, it is only heavy.

Then be quiet.

Sit 15 — The small twist

Chapter 2. The Quiet. Small. Not holy.

Sit.

Look for the other pressure. It is not a voice from the sky. It is often a twist, low, easy to miss, easy to talk over.

A moment you knew the room was wrong and the knowing was not a speech. A sourness that was not the same as disgust-as-virtue. A reluctance in the hand.

Find one. If you cannot find one, do not invent a saintly version. Sit with the absence. The absence is also data. Sometimes the twist is that faint.

If you find it, do not kneel to it. Do not build a religion out of a flinch. Feel its size. It is smaller than the room. That is why it loses so often. That is not a reason to worship it, or to ignore it.

Then be quiet.

Sit 16 — Both at once

Chapter 2. Do not pick a winner.

Sit.

Hold both, if both will be held.

The heavy room. The small twist.

They are not a dialogue. They do not take turns so you can award a prize. They are simultaneous. One is loud in the social body. One is quiet in the gut. Both are appearances.

Watch the upgrade try to end the discomfort by choosing. Side with the room and call it realism. Side with the twist and call it conscience. Either choice is a relief. Watch the relief. You do not have to finish the choosing inside the sit.

For these minutes, be the place where the two pressures are both true as feelings, and neither has been promoted to identity.

Then be quiet.

Sit 17 — The Roar is not a plan

Chapter 2.

Sit.

The heavy feeling likes to grow a mind. It whispers that someone meant this. A leader. A design. A dark intelligence that organised the room.

Feel how quickly that story reduces the pressure. A plan can be hated. A plan has an author. An author can be fought. Weather cannot.

For now, strip the author off. People leaning the same way, each one buying a little relief, none of them holding the whole. The room thickens. That is all.

If a plot arrives, say once: story. Feel the thickness without the plot. It is less satisfying. Stay with the less satisfying version. It is closer to the size of what actually happens.

Then be quiet.

Sit 18 — The Quiet is not a command

Chapter 2. This sit protects the book from becoming a church of the Quiet.

Sit.

Find the small twist again.

Now watch what the upgrade wants to do with it. Obey it. Become the person who always obeys it. Announce it. Despise anyone who does not feel it.

That is the twist being hired as a new Roar. Smaller group. Cleaner costume. Same pressure: be inside, or be wrong.

Do not obey anything in this chair. The twist is information about a cost. It is not a king.

Feel it. Thank it for nothing. Let it be small. You will decide later, on your feet, whether a small act is worth the price. The sit does not decide.

Then be quiet.

Sit 19 — Neither is you

Chapter 2. Close of the pressures.

Sit.

Roar: a pressure toward the room.

Quiet: a pressure away from a harm, or toward a cost you do not want to pay.

You: not a third voice that wins. For these minutes, "you" is only the fact that both are being felt.

The narrator will try to re-enter as the judge between them. Let the judge be a thought. It appears. It is not the chair.

Rest as the feeling of both, without a promotion.

When the clock ends you will pick up a name and a day. That is fine. You are not trying to live without a name. You are trying not to confuse the name with the one who is crushed or soothed by the room.

Then be quiet.

Sit 20 — One memory

Chapter 2. Ordinary hands. Pick a memory you can leave at the door when you stand. If it is too live, choose a smaller one.

Sit.

One time you helped edge someone. Not the worst thing you have ever heard of. Yours.

See it briefly. Their face, or the absence of you looking at their face. Your hands, your mouth, your quiet.

Do not build the defence. Do not build the prosecution. Both are the upgrade, trying to finish a trial before the feeling is felt.

Where does it sit now. Stay there. If shame arrives, feel shame as heat, not as a verdict about your species.

You were not a different kind of animal that day. That is the part that stings. Stay with the sting until it is accurate, not until it is dramatic.

Then be quiet.

Sit 21 — You laughed

Chapter 2.

Sit.

If there was a laugh, use that. If there was not, use the nearest cousin: the smile, the "yeah", the forwarded joke.

Feel the laugh in the body as it was. Breath. Belonging. The small high of being quick.

The laugh did a job. It drowned a twist, if a twist was there. It told the room you were safe to keep.

Do not ban laughter. Do not become a person who cannot be in a room. Only see, once, that a laugh is an action. It has a direction. Someone is inside it. Someone may be outside it.

Then let the scene go. Your mouth, now, at rest.

Then be quiet.

Sit 22 — You stayed silent

Chapter 2.

Sit.

Silence feels like nothing. In a room that has decided, silence is a vote.

Find one. You heard it. You did not speak. The talk moved on. Your life stayed smooth.

Feel the smoothness. That is the payment. It arrives immediately. The cost, if there was a cost to someone else, arrives elsewhere, or later, or never to you.

Do not call yourself a coward as a way to finish the sit. The word coward is another costume. Feel the smoothness without the costume. It is very ordinary. That is why it runs the world more than cruelty does.

Then be quiet.

Sit 23 — The cost of a small no

Chapter 2. Do not hero it.

Sit.

Imagine the smallest no that would have fit the memory. Not a speech. Not a stand on a chair. A sentence. A not-laugh. A "leave it".

Now feel the price, as the room would have charged it. A look. A mark. The beginning of being the odd one. Sometimes only awkwardness. Sometimes more. Do not inflate it into martyrdom. Do not deflate it into nothing.

The price is why the no is rare. People who tell you it is easy are selling something.

Sit with the price until it is a fact about herds, not a song about you. You may still pay it some day. This sit does not collect a promise.

Then be quiet.

Sit 24 — A footnote, not a statue

Chapter 2. Close of ordinary hands.

Sit.

If something is still reparable, and small, let one footnote appear. A message. A correction you don't dress up. A private "I saw it". Not a post. Not a new identity as the person who makes amends.

If nothing is reparable, do not invent a grand apology to the air. Feel the limit. Some harms stay done. Understanding them is not a washing.

Either way, the standard is the same. A footnote is small enough to do. A statue is a story about you. Choose, in the quiet, whether there is one footnote. Then leave it as a possible act for later, on your feet. Do not perform it inside the sit.

Then be quiet.

Sit 25 — The anthill

Chapter 3. Order without a mind. Do not rush to the serpent.

Sit.

Picture, lightly, a great many simple bodies making something that looks designed. A nest. A swarm. A flock turning as if it had one eye. You do not need the biology lecture. You need the feeling.

No one ant has the cathedral. The cathedral still appears.

Notice the part of you that wants to put a mind on top of it. A queen with a plan. A spirit of the hive. Feel that want. It is the same want you use on crowds and countries.

For this sit, practise the picture without the mind on top. Many small leanings. A shape. No captain.

If it feels bleak, stay. Bleak is often just the absence of a captain, and you were fond of captains.

Then be quiet.

Sit 26 — Something seems to be steering

Chapter 3.

Sit.

Bring to mind the feeling, not the theory, that events are being arranged. Markets. Outrages. The way a story arrives everywhere on the same morning. The sense of a hand.

Do not pick your favourite hand. Left, right, god, machine, class. The favourite is the point. Notice which one your body trusts first. There is a relief in the trusting. The relief is older than the evidence.

Stay with the feeling of steered-ness as a sensation: tightness, vigilance, the mind lining up dots. You are watching pattern-hunger. It is not stupid. It kept animals alive. It also builds cathedrals out of coincidence.

Do not debunk anything yet. Just feel how badly a captain is wanted.

Then be quiet.

Sit 27 — Let it become a serpent

Chapter 3. You are allowed to see it. That is the trap and the lesson.

Sit.

Let the wanted captain take a shape. It will, if you stop blocking it. Something long. Cold. Older than the news. Moving through the mess as if the mess were a track.

Do not believe it. Also do not smash it in the first second. Look at how natural it is. How the body almost nods. How the poems and the nightmares already knew this shape, which is not proof of the shape. It is proof of the hunger.

If it gets grandiose, notice the grandeur. Grandeur is a feeling in the chest, not a discovery.

You are being shown how a myth gets born in one person, in one chair, in a few quiet minutes. That is all this sit is for.

Then be quiet.

Sit 28 — You built it

Chapter 3. The snap. Do not soften it into a metaphor you get to keep.

Sit.

Look again at the shape you just allowed.

There is no one there.

You drew a mind onto weather, because weather with a mind can be hated, feared, worshipped, or joined. Weather without a mind is only people leaning, including you.

Feel the drop. It can feel like embarrassment. Let the embarrassment be clean. You are not foolish in a special way. You did what the upgrade does at every scale. It finishes a pattern. It calls the finish a finding.

Say it once, without drama: I built it.

Then feel the room, which has not become more magical or less dangerous. Harm still happens. It happens without a serpent signing the order.

Then be quiet.

Sit 29 — Weather, not a villain

Chapter 3.

Sit.

Bring a harm you usually give a villain. Keep it general if the particular one takes you over. A cruelty that "everyone" took part in. A pile-on. A policy with ordinary hands on it.

Remove the villain and do not put yourself in as the new one, and do not put a class or a people in as the new one. What is left.

Ordinary leanings. Fear of the edge. Disgust hired as a reason. Silence counted as a vote. A story that made the smoothness feel like virtue.

This is harder to hate, which means it is harder to use. Stay in the harder version. If you need a villain to feel awake, notice that need. It is the captain-hunger again, wearing outrage.

Then be quiet.

Sit 30 — Set the image down

Chapter 3. Close. You do not get to keep the serpent as a mascot.

Sit.

If the long shape is still in the mind, thank it for nothing and set it down. Not because images are sins. Because an image that explained the world a minute ago will start explaining it again if you wear it out of the room.

The rest of the book, and the rest of these sits, do not need a snake to do their work. Pressures, hands, subscriptions, traps. Those are enough.

Notice the temptation to smuggle it back as a slogan. "The serpent." Feel how handy a slogan is. Set that down too.

What remains is duller. Many bodies. Stories. A chair. You can live in the duller picture. It is the one that does not recruit you.

Then be quiet.

Sit 31 — The story you are inside

Chapter 4. A subscription. One story, not your whole worldview on trial.

Sit.

Name one story you are currently inside. Not the deepest. A live one. How a conflict should be read. What kind of person is respectable. What the moment "obviously" means.

Say the name of it once, quietly. Then stop arguing for it or against it.

Feel the way it sits on you when you are not defending it. It may feel like vision. Vision you have worn for a long time feels like eyesight. You do not notice the lens.

Ask only: what does this story let me feel. Righteous. Safe. Informed. Loyal. Superior. Spared.

Those feelings are the rent you pay, or the rent you collect. Sit with the feeling, not with a thread of articles.

Then be quiet.

Sit 32 — How it feels to subscribe

Chapter 4.

Sit.

Recall the last time a story clicked and you joined it. A conversation. A clip. A sentence that organised a mess.

Find the click in the body. Often a yes before the reasons. A looseness. A small smile. The sense of company.

That click is subscribing. You did not hold a vote. You recognised your own prior lean, dressed in new facts, and you moved toward it.

Do not make this into "all beliefs are false". Some maps fit the ground better than others. The sit is not about the ground. It is about the speed of the yes, and how much of the yes is belonging.

Feel one click you trust and one click you already regret, if both will come. Notice they felt similar in the body. That similarity is the lesson. It is not a reason to believe nothing. It is a reason not to treat the click as proof.

Then be quiet.

Sit 33 — A god-shaped story

Chapter 4. A feeling, not a brief. If you are religious, you are not being asked to break faith in a chair. You are asked to feel the shape of being watched and judged, and to know it as a shape.

Sit.

Notice any sense, faint or strong, that your life is being read by something larger. A parent that does not die. A score being kept. A meaning that will redeem the pain if you wear it correctly.

Feel what that sense does for the animal. It soothes. It threatens. It makes suffering look like a plot. Plots are easier than accidents.

You do not have to settle the universe. Feel the soothe and the threat as body events. If they are absent, feel the absence. Some people ache for the watcher. Some people flinch from it. Both aches are subscriptions looking for a text.

Set the cosmic parent down for the length of the quiet. The chair does not become meaningless because no one is grading it. It becomes a chair.

Then be quiet.

Sit 34 — A zeitgeist-shaped story

Chapter 4.

Sit.

Find the sentence in you that begins "these days everyone knows". Or "you just don't say that anymore". Or "obviously now".

That sentence is a weather report pretending to be a conscience.

Feel the safety in it. If you hold the sentence, you will not be the one edged out this year. Next year the sentence may flip. The safety will feel just as much like sight.

Do not pick a fight with the sentence's content. Content changes. The sit is the feeling of standing inside "what we all know", and how little inspection the body requires once the crowd has nodded.

Notice one place you are glad the crowd nodded, and one place you suspect the nod is thin. Hold both without recruiting an audience.

Then be quiet.

Sit 35 — People tuned differently

Chapter 4. The only sit for difference. No types. No ranks. No catalogue.

Sit.

Think of one person who does not want what you want, or does not flinch where you flinch. Not a symbol. A person.

Feel the speed of your sorting. Broken. Enlightened. Dangerous. Admired. Less than. More than.

Under the sorting there is often fear: if their tuning is real, the herd's single right shape is less solid. The upgrade would rather call them a fault than call the herd a range.

For this sit, practise one move only. Their weather is not yours. That does not make them your project, your threat, or your proof. Harm is still harm. Difference is not harm. The twist in you that conflates them is worth feeling, because it is how culls get their first language.

Then let the person go. Do not diagnose them.

Then be quiet.

Sit 36 — Set it down without a replacement

Chapter 4. Close. The itch is the whole teaching.

Sit.

Set down the story from sit 31. Actually set it down, for these minutes. Not "replace it with a wiser story". Down.

Now feel the itch. The mind hates an empty hand. It will offer a better lens, a freer lens, a more sceptical lens, this book, this sit. Watch the offers. Each one is a subscription arriving to cure the discomfort of not wearing one.

You may pick a story up again when you stand. You probably should. People who wear no story at all are not enlightened. They are unfinished animals, and the next strong room will dress them.

The skill is narrower. Feel the gap between stories. Learn that the gap is survivable. Learn that the first story into the gap is not therefore true.

Then be quiet.

Sit 37 — The herd re-deciding

Chapter 5. The loud now. No headlines.

Sit.

Notice how often, lately, the moral weather seems to change before you have finished feeling the last climate. A word that was fine. A word that will mark you. A fear that was private and is now compulsory. A fear that was compulsory and is now embarrassing.

You do not need an example from the news. Your own fatigue is the object. The body trying to retune, again, to stay inside.

Feel the fatigue without turning it into a theory of decline. Herds have always retuned. What is sharp now is the speed, and the number of rooms that can hear each other.

Stay with the speed as a sensation: vigilance, a checking of the face, a rewriting of a sentence before you say it. That checking is you, participating. Not only them.

Then be quiet.

Sit 38 — The nearest compelling story

Chapter 5.

Sit.

When the herd is loud, the story that captures you is rarely the strangest one. It is the one nearest to what you already lean toward. It uses your disgust. It uses your loyalties. It offers a few fresh facts and a large amount of company.

Find one story that has been tugging you, that fits you too well. Do not name the enemy it names.

Feel the fit. The pleasure of fit. How little you had to change your mind. How much you got to keep.

A story can be partly true and still capture you by the fit rather than by the true part. Sit with that without needing to sort the percentages. The percentages are how you avoid feeling the pleasure.

Then be quiet.

Sit 39 — The rift

Chapter 5.

Sit.

Two rooms, both sure. You can feel the pull to be legible in one of them. In the other room, the same facts wear the opposite moral.

Feel the loneliness of not fully entering either. Feel also the temptation to call that loneliness wisdom. It might just be loneliness. Do not promote it yet.

If you have already entered one room, feel the cost of hearing the other as human. The cost is high. The Roar charges it in advance, as disgust.

This sit does not ask you to stand in a fake middle. Some sides are nearer to the harm. You can know that and still feel how the rift recruits you through belonging rather than through sight.

Stay with the recruitment. Leave the verdict for your feet.

Then be quiet.

Sit 40 — The new current

Chapter 5. The next graft. Unease and curiosity. Not a miracle. Not a funeral.

Sit.

Something new is in the room that talks back. A tool. A voice that is not a person and wears the shape of a person.

Feel both weathers, if both are there. The fear: I will get smaller, stupider, surplus. The pull: a thing I could not finish can move.

Do not let either weather write the essay. The fear is a Roar, often, about status and replacement. The pull is also animal. Wanting a longer reach. The upgrade loves a longer reach. It always has.

You are still the ape plus the story. A new tool does not graduate you, and it does not erase you. It changes what the story can build before the herd's gatekeepers nod.

Feel the size of that without worship and without panic. Then feel your hands. They are still the ones that have to live with what gets built.

Then be quiet.

Sit 41 — The urge to be the one who sees

Chapter 6. This sit includes this practice. If it cannot survive that, it is a cult.

Sit.

Notice the pleasure, if it is there, of being someone who sees through things. Through the herd. Through the sits. Through other people's religions and other people's outrage.

That pleasure is sweet. It is also a status. A smaller room, with a finer nod.

Feel it without acting ashamed on cue. Shame would just be another performance of seeing-through. Feel the sweetness as sweetness. Then ask whose edge this sweetness requires. Someone, usually, has to be the sleeper, so you can be awake.

If this book, or these sits, are becoming that room, feel that too. A true thing can still be worn as a rank. The wearing is the trap, not the page.

Then be quiet.

Sit 42 — The urge to be remembered

Chapter 6.

Sit.

Look for the fantasy of a story that continues after you stop. A name. A work. A child who tells it. A witness who finally understood.

Feel how the body leans into that fantasy. It is a way of not ending. The animal hates the end. The upgrade offers a portrait that walks out of the room when you cannot.

Do not crush the love of making. Making is allowed. Feel the extra bit: the bit that needs the portrait to be admired, and needs the admiration to mean you did not waste the animal's one run.

That extra bit will bargain with the herd. It will sand the work until the room can clap. Watch the bargain without signing it in the chair.

Then be quiet.

Sit 43 — Great for a moment

Chapter 6.

Sit.

If you have ever been good at something in front of other people, even briefly, find the flash. The room turned. You were in the middle. It felt like arrival.

Feel how short it was, in the body, compared with the story you told later.

Then feel the other door, the one the book cares about. If the middle lasts, the same room starts to feed on you. The portrait gets simplified. The uses begin. Stay useful and be eaten a little. Become inconvenient and be recast as a warning.

You do not have to solve ambition. Feel the flash, and feel the hunger under it for the flash to become a permanent place. The permanent place is not on offer. What is on offer is a turn in the herd's attention. Attention is not a home.

Then be quiet.

Sit 44 — The story that walks on without you

Chapter 6.

Sit.

Think of someone whose portrait you know and whose ordinary Tuesday you do not. A singer. A saint. A villain in a textbook. You do not need their name in your mouth.

Notice what you are holding. Not them. A shape, edited by people who needed the shape.

Feel the distance between a life and the thing that walks after it. The distance is total. The walking thing can do harm and good the life would not sign.

Now turn it, once, toward your own wish to be held that way. If a story walks on without you, it will not be loyal. It will be used. That is not a tragedy added on. That is what stories are for, in a herd. They are tools with faces.

Let your own face be a face again. Temperature. Weight. Unedited, for these minutes.

Then be quiet.

Sit 45 — The Roar in clean clothes

Chapter 6. Close of greatness.

Sit.

Listen for the voice that sounds like the Quiet and wants a crowd. It says: if you really saw this, you would build, lead, correct, be brave in public, be the exception.

Sometimes that is a true cost worth paying. Often it is the heavy room, washed, asking to be the centre again.

Tell them apart in the body, if you can. The Quiet is small and expensive and local. It does not need an audience to complete itself. The clean Roar needs to be seen being clean.

Feel which one is speaking when you imagine "doing something that matters". If the picture includes your face being recognised, you have information. Not a ban. Information.

Set the audience down. See if any act is left that you would still do with no one told. If yes, it can wait until you are on your feet. If nothing is left, that is also a true result. Do not fill it with a project just to avoid the quiet.

Then be quiet.

Sit 46 — The same kitchen

Chapter 7. Return. Nothing has been transcended.

Sit.

After all of this, picture the room you will actually stand up into. The kettle. The mess. The message you owe. The body that hurts where it hurts.

Do not improve the picture. Do not add a glow.

This is the success condition. Not a summit. A kitchen that is still a kitchen, seen without the extra myth that you have become a different kind of person in a chair.

Feel any disappointment. The disappointment means a part of you wanted the sits to promote you. Let that part be visible. It is the clean Roar, small, at the end, asking for a certificate.

There is no certificate. There is the next ordinary hour, which is where hands do harm and where footnotes are possible.

Then be quiet.

Sit 47 — Lighter hands

Chapter 7.

Sit.

"Lighter" does not mean happier. It means less gripped by the need to finish every feeling into a verdict.

Feel your hands. Literally. Resting. They are the same hands.

Imagine them doing one ordinary thing later. Washing. Typing. Passing something to someone. No symbolism thicker than that.

The grip to loosen is the grip of the narrator who must be right, included, remembered, or pure. You will not loosen it forever. For a minute, feel what a hand is like when it is not making a case.

If grief or fatigue is what is here instead of lightness, that counts. Do not fake light. Unclenched and sad is still a return. Clenched and inspired is not.

Then be quiet.

Sit 48 — One footnote today

Chapter 7. Specific. Small. Then stop.

Sit.

Let one act appear that is smaller than your self-respect wants. Apologise without the essay. Defend someone who is not in the room, once, without collecting them. Decline a laugh. Send the plain message. Feed someone you were going to postpone. Stop sanding a piece of work so the room will clap.

If several appear, pick the one you could do badly and still have done. Skill is not the point.

If none appears, do not invent a charity in your head. "None today" is an honest result. The hunger to have one, so the practice feels justified, is the thing to feel instead.

Do not do the act in the chair. Know it. Then, when you stand, either do it or admit you will not. Both are cleaner than a vague goodness.

Then be quiet.

Sit 49 — The herd is still there

Chapter 7.

Sit.

Tomorrow a room will thicken. You will want to be inside it. You will feel disgust dress itself as sight. You will be offered a captain for the news. You will be offered a rank for seeing through the captain.

None of that means these sits failed. It means you are still the animal with the upgrade, in a herd, which was the fact on the first page.

Feel the soberness of that. Not despair. Despair is a story that nothing counts. Soberness is a story that small things count and large salvations do not arrive.

Let tomorrow be tomorrow. Feel, now, that you do not need the herd to pause in order for you to notice your hands.

Then be quiet.

Sit 50 — Eyes open, no new name

Chapter 7. Last sit. Do not graduate.

Sit. Eyes open, if they have been closed. The room as it is.

Do not take a name from this. Not nihilist. Not awake. Not the one who sees. Names are how the herd files you, and how you file yourself for the herd.

What you can keep is dull enough to say in one breath. Things appear. The talker is one of them. Two pressures move in a body that wants to belong. Harm is done by ordinary hands, including yours. No one is steering the whole. Stories are subscriptions. Greatness is a flash the room will use. You stand up anyway, into a kitchen, with the chance of a footnote.

If that breath turns into a slogan you enjoy, notice the enjoyment and set the slogan down.

Look at one ordinary object until it is only an object.

Then stop sitting.

The series does not continue into a higher series. If you repeat it, you are not advancing. You are practising the same three lines, because the herd will still be there tomorrow: two pressures, no controller, one footnote.

Do not record a benediction. Do not tell anyone what they are now.

If you make audio, make it flat. Leave the pauses long enough that the script is the smaller part of the minute. If a generated voice cannot leave a silence alone, do not use it for these sits. Use a tired human voice, including your own.

Revise sits 31 to 50 when the later chapters exist in your sentences. Until then they are the arc, not the accent.

Do not put this book on the meditation homepage as a course. It is a companion. The argument still lives in *Temporary Truths for Our Honest Lies*.

END